ARES Lesson Library - User Guide

Lesson3 v0.94 | Complete offline reference | October 2026

Use Lesson3 to find and read ARES lesson plans. When you download a plan, Lesson3 makes the Word or PDF file for you.

Use **Lessons** to find plans, a **lesson page** to read and share one plan, **Manage** to edit lessons and manage accounts, and **Messages** to contact other people with Lesson3 accounts. People with editing access also see saved-version and comparison controls.

This is the complete offline reference. The in-app guide at `/guide` shows an overview of each area and gives detailed steps only for tasks available to the signed-in user. Keep the facts in both guides in step when either changes.

At a glance

Teachers	Find, read, download, discuss, favorite, share, and request editing access.
Editors	Update lesson content, save versions, restore work, compare, and discuss changes.
Subject-grade administrators	Manage structure, access, settings, and Official versions.
Site administrators	Manage the whole site, accounts, curriculum, discussions, and system status.

Teachers

Use Lessons to find and read plans or download their Word and PDF files. Each plan opens at its Official version. If you have editing or administrator access, you also see an N versions panel and Compare button.

- **Your account:** create one from the sign-in page's Sign up link, then follow the verification link we email you before signing in. Forgot password? on the same page emails you a reset link. If your school's Lesson3 site cannot send email - some run with no internet - ask a Site administrator to create and verify your account. They can also create a reset link and give it to you directly. For security your session ends after a while and signs you out automatically - just sign in again to continue.
- **Browse lesson plans:** the home page groups lessons by subject and grade, then by strand and sub-strand in curriculum order.
- **Search and filter:** use the search box to find a subject, grade, strand, or sub-strand, and use the subject and grade buttons to narrow the list. Search and filters work together.
- **Favorites:** click the star on a library row - or the Favorite Favorite button on a lesson page - to keep that lesson in My favorites at the top of the home page. Teachers see the current Official version when one is promoted. With editing access, a favorite stays on the exact version you chose; Lesson3 marks it vX `(pinned)`. Favorites are private.
- **Read on screen:** open a sub-strand to view the Lesson Sequence, Final Explanation, and Summary Table when those documents are present.
- **Student document and Teacher key:** the Final explanation you download has blank answer space and no answers, so it is the one to give to students. The Teacher key - not for students has the same questions with the exemplar answers: the Teacher key has the exemplar answers and is not for students. It appears beside the Final explanation, wherever one exists, and travels with Download all and Email all.
- **Open or download a document:** on the home page, each lesson row has a PDF button (opens in a new tab) and a Word button (downloads its `.docx` - on a phone, Word is available by email instead) for the lesson plan, with any Final Explanation or Summary Table behind a Supporting documents line. A lesson page has its own PDF and Word buttons for the lesson plan, in the action bar immediately before Share; every other download lives in the Share menu: the supporting documents one at a time under Download one document, plus Download all as a Word or PDF `.zip`. On a phone the Word downloads are omitted - use Email all - Word, or a

larger screen.

- **Email:** choose Share -> Email all - Word or Email all - PDF on a lesson page to send the generated documents (as a .zip of that format) to any email address - your own, or a colleague's. Sends are limited per day.
- **Want to edit?** use Request editing access on a lesson page. Lesson3 notifies the administrators for that subject and grade. You can request access once a day for each subject and grade. The limit applies separately to each teacher.
- **Messages:** open Messages from the menu under your avatar (top right) to send a note to anyone with a Lesson3 account - a lesson page's Share -> Message a colleague item attaches that lesson to your note. Each message you receive has a Reply button that opens a box to write straight back. Unread messages show as a small count on your avatar, and you get a short email telling you a message is waiting (never its content). Opening Messages marks everything shown as read.

Discussions

Discussions are on by default. A Site administrator can switch them off; the Discuss item and forum entry points then disappear, and existing discussions are kept.

- Open **Discuss -> Start a discussion**, write a title and post, then choose **Post**. Every signed-in user can read and reply. Name the lesson and the question or change. Write plain text; web links become clickable. Replies appear oldest first. Pinned topics stay above the list of latest activity.
- **Search covers titles only.** Posts cannot be edited. Only a Site administrator can delete a thread. You can make up to 100 posts per day, including replies.
- **Add lesson reference** finds a lesson by title, then lets you choose one of its saved versions. You can remove a prefilled reference before posting. **Share -> Discuss this version** on a lesson page opens a discussion with that version already attached. **Compare changes** appears when its source version is still available. If the referenced version is deleted, its label remains with no link to another version.
- **The blue dot** means new posts in discussions you started or replied to, or discussions started about a saved version you authored. Your own replies do not light the dot. A blue marker identifies the unread thread in the list. Reading alone does not subscribe you. Reading a thread marks the posts shown as read. Follow reply pages in order; jumping ahead leaves earlier posts unread. The dot updates on navigation or reload.
- **Your forum text stays only in the form.** Copy it before leaving, reloading or signing in again. If a result is uncertain, keep the form open and choose **Try again**; the fields stay locked until Lesson3 finds the post or confirms it was posted.

Editing

With editing access, you can change most lesson content in Lesson3. The subjects and grades you can edit depend on your role. Subject-grade and Site administrators can also edit. Make changes in Lesson3, not in a Word file.

- **Edit from the lesson:** open a lesson in the library and press Edit. The editing page opens ready to type, showing only the fields you may change. Quick preview checks your content, while Formatted PDF shows the final layout. Both open in a new tab and include unsaved edits; close that tab to return to the editor. Use Help for the short writing rules. Back at the top right returns you when you are done.
- **Saving makes a new version:** Save stores your edits as a new version and leaves the version you opened unchanged. A Subject-grade or Site administrator marks a saved version Official when it is ready.
- **Find your saved versions:** Manage -> Lesson plans -> My saved versions lists versions you saved. Choose one to continue editing, or delete one you no longer need.
- **Post about these changes:** after saving a version, choose this button beside **Compare to Official** on your saved version. It opens a discussion with that version attached. Explain what changed and invite colleagues' suggestions. Starting a discussion that references someone else's saved version includes its author in the discussion's blue-dot notifications.
- **Unsaved work:** while you edit, a note below the buttons shows when Lesson3 last saved a temporary copy of your changes. Only you can see it, even if someone else uses the same computer. Lesson3 will not restore it unless you choose to.

- **Restore unsaved work:** if you leave without saving, reopen that version. Lesson3 will ask whether you want to restore your changes. New wording appears in green; saved wording that will be replaced is struck through in red. Lesson3 normally shows only the changes you have not saved. Some changes cannot be shown word by word: Emptied means a field will be cleared, Paragraph breaks changed means only line breaks changed, and Spacing only means the words stayed the same. You can restore the changes, decide later, or discard them. Discarding cannot be undone.
- **If someone else saves a newer version while you are away:** Lesson3 cannot restore your changes automatically. Lesson3 shows all your unsaved work so you can copy what you still need.
- **Compare two versions:** choose Compare in the N versions panel. Removals appear in red and additions in green. Lesson3 lists the parts that changed; choose one to jump to it. Turn off Changes only to read both versions in full. If a part says Spacing or document structure changed, the words are the same but arranged differently.

Subject-grade administrators

Subject-grade administrators can edit lesson text, give or remove editing access, change lesson structure, and choose which version is Official for their subjects and grades.

- **Manage lesson structure:** add, remove, and reorder lessons and lesson phases. To add a lesson, copy an existing lesson, then edit the copy.
- **Change lesson settings:** update Document settings, the Sub-strand overview, lesson duration, ARES keywords, lesson phases, assessment examples, and rubric rows.
- **Make Official:** on a lesson page, promote a saved version to the Official one Teachers see - optionally deleting the version it replaces.
- **Review saved versions:** Manage -> Lesson plans -> Candidate versions lists saved versions that are not Official for your subjects and grades. Open one to review it or delete one you no longer need.
- **Roles & Access:** Manage -> Users -> Roles & Access lets you give or remove editing access for a subject and grade. Check the person's email address before changing access; two people can have the same display name.
- **Hand over your administrator role:** in the same panel, choose someone who already has editing access for that subject and grade. Confirm to make them the administrator. You keep editing access but lose administrator access. Only a Site administrator can make you an administrator again.

Site administrators

Site administrators can manage all accounts, subjects, grades, and lesson plans.

- **Set up the first administrators:** if no account exists yet, the sign-in page shows a one-time Create the first Site administrator form. There is no default username or password. After creating the first account, create and test a second Site administrator so someone can still manage the site if you forget your password.
- **Manage lesson plans:** upload ARES JSON files or ZIP archives of JSON files. Valid files are imported even when others fail; review the report for imported, rejected and skipped files. Unchanged files are skipped, so you can re-upload a corrected ZIP after a partial import. New plans receive their first Official version; changed content for an existing sub-strand creates a Not Official revision for review. You can also repair plans that have no Official version, delete lesson plans (with all their versions), and reach the People and Curriculum lists.
- **Create accounts without email:** use Manage -> Users -> Accounts -> Create user, then open the new account and choose Mark verified. The person cannot sign in until that is done. Use Make Site Administrator when the new account should be another Site administrator, and test it in a private browser window.
- **Manage people:** make someone a Site administrator only if they need to manage the whole site. Give editing access or appoint a Subject-grade administrator for each subject and grade they manage. Only a Site administrator can appoint, replace, or remove a Subject-grade administrator. A Subject-grade administrator can hand over their role to someone who already has editing access, but cannot remove another administrator.
- **Reset a password when email is unavailable:** If email is not available, create a password-reset link and give it to the person. They use the link to choose a new password. You will not see their password.

- **Check site and backup status:** Manage -> System -> Installation status shows the site address, whether email and public sharing are available, whether PDFs are working, where backups are sent, when the last backup succeeded, and whether this site keeps the key needed to open its backups. A successful backup means an encrypted copy was sent; it does not prove the backup can be restored. You cannot change these installation settings on this page. Ask the person who manages the server to change them.
- **Switch Discussions on or off:** in **Manage -> System -> Features**, change **Discussions enabled** and choose **Save**. Review the change and enter your password. The switch stays unchanged until Save succeeds. If someone else saved settings first, reload before saving.
- **Moderate discussions:** on a thread, use **Pin** or **Unpin** to change its position. **Redact topic** lets you remove the title, opening post, or both; **Redact reply** removes one reply's text. Redaction cannot be undone. Existing backups keep the text until they age out. **Delete thread** removes the entire thread and every reply, and cannot be undone. Each action asks for confirmation. While the forum is off, follow **Moderate discussions** beside the switch to read, redact or delete. This view has no search, posting, pinning or unread tracking.
- **Set up subjects and grades:** add subjects and grades before uploading lesson plans.
- **Manage all lesson plans:** open, edit, download, mark Official, or delete plans across all subjects and grades.

Writing in Fields

These rules are also available from Help at the top of the editor.

- Start a new line to make a new paragraph.
- Start a line with - to make a bullet.
- Use Insert link beneath a text field to add a web address or choose a PDF already available on this Lesson3 site. The address appears in parentheses and becomes clickable on screen and in the Word/PDF files. Web and PDF links open separately so your editor stays open.
- Bold, italics, and underlining are not supported.
- Change the field for the section you want to update. Lesson3 makes the Word and PDF files from these fields.

Role Notes

- Access is set separately for each subject and grade. For example, access to Biology Grade 10 does not include Biology Grade 11.
- Every lesson plan has one **Official** version at a time. Teachers see it first. It does not control who can open other saved versions; anyone who is signed in can open a saved version if they have its link.
- Teachers with editing access and Subject-grade administrators can work only with the subjects and grades assigned to them. Site administrators can manage the whole site.
- Only the account owner and Site administrators can see an email address. In Manage -> Users -> Roles & Access, Subject-grade administrators can see addresses only for people listed under the subjects and grades they manage.

Lesson Plans by ARES Education and Seavuria

Donate to ARES Education | Donate to Seavuria